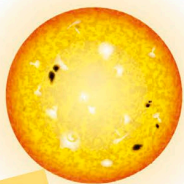


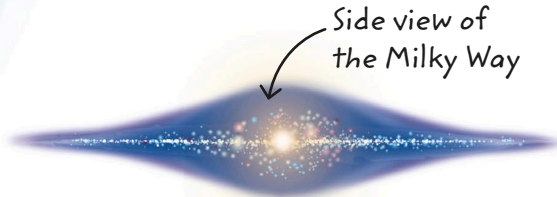
Just one of the stars

Although the Sun is special to us, it is just another star in the galaxy. The Sun lies in one of the spiral arms, about one-third of the way out from the galaxy's center.



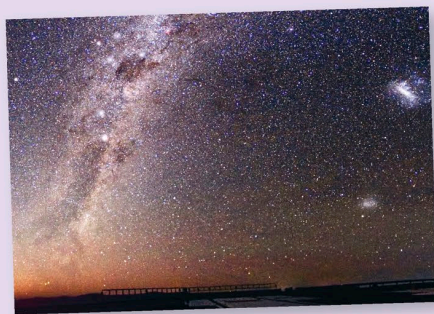
The ancient Greeks thought that the Milky Way was milk spilled by baby Heracles (Hercules) as Hera, the queen of the heavens, fed him her milk.

Side view of the Milky Way



Side view

From out in space, the Milky Way looks like a huge pancake. A side view shows the bulge at its center, where most of the stars live. From Earth, you see a band full of stars stretching across the night sky.



Milky Way—southern sky

Wherever you live in the world, you can see the path of the Milky Way. It is most spectacular in the sky above the southern half of Earth. Here, you can look to the galaxy's center.



Milky Way—northern sky

You can see the path of the Milky Way with the naked eye. However, using binoculars will show you that the milky light is made of thousands and thousands of stars.